

Missing Mrs G

Those who are marketing the martyrdom of Indira Gandhi are yet to discover the India that romanced her.
Why the meek can never inherit Indira.

By S. Prasannarajan

In the subcontinental mythology of power, she is still the Awesome One. Mother Boundless. Angry Goddess. Empress of Enigma. Matron Saint of Paranoia... Indira Gandhi continues to be reborn in the memory of a nation as avatars of affection, admiration, adoration and fear. Twenty-five years after her assassination on the morning of October 31, we still miss her, and not because of the simulated nostalgia of those who claim copyright over her political legacy in this season of commemorative frenzy. Is it then a measure of her exceptionalism or a reflection of the pathology of the current leadership in politics? Her journey from the cloistered privileges of Anand Bhavan in Allahabad to the absolute power of 1 Safdarjung Road in Delhi to the collective consciousness of India—or her transformation from the frail, lonely “Indu boy” to the Intimate Indira of the masses—essays the passions and mystique of power.

Words that denote the banality of power today—words like dynasty and populism—resonate differently when they appear in the narrative of her evolution. The Gandhi cult—not of loincloth-and-spinning-wheel but of starched-cotton-and-parted-hair—is arguably the most enduring legacy in hereditary politics today. It all began with her, in spite of the bloodline going

back to Motilal Nehru, and she would consecrate it with her own blood. As in every dynastic script, from the very beginning, she was told of the symbiosis between her destiny and history. The father, always a storyteller of grand sweep, wrote to her that she was born in the month of Russian revolution, in a world of “storm and trouble”. Stormy it would remain till the very end but she would not be swept away. Unlike her children and grandchildren, and the daughter-in-law of course, she would not have an easy start. She had to fight and win within the party first. And those men were not in awe of her—or of her pedigree—either.

They were not as dependent or servile as the average Congressman we meet today: someone who cannot think of his political existence beyond the re-

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assuring shadow of a Gandhi; someone who is kept alive by Our Lady of Deliverance. And the original Mrs G was not born out of the collective desperation of a wailing legion of Congressmen either. She had to be smarter than those wily old men of the Syndicate who thought she would be a pawn in their hands. She had to be ruthless. The legend of the strong leader always begins with the story of the novice outplaying the so-called kingmakers. Indira, the archetypal strong leader, would become the political equivalent of the sacred feminine in a culture that venerates Mother Goddess, who embodies amelioration as well as annihilation. Even the poetic flourish of an Atal Bihari Vajpayee could not resist the Durga imagery as a triumphant, post-Bangladesh Indira walked into an ecstatic House.

We also know that gods and goddesses in politics are connoisseurs of kitsch, the art of playing with the mass mind. A character in a Milan Kundera novel cries out, “My enemy is not communism but kitsch”, which the novelist says is the aesthetic ideal of totalitarianism. Elsewhere, from Eva Peron to Imelda Marcos to Jayalalithaa, it was the art of kitsch that made them performers of mass salvation. Mrs G’s socialist populism, quite Soviet in many aspects, was a more evolved version of kitsch on a national scale. Soon it would become